

As much as we might like to deny it, computer viruses in their various guises have made people paranoid. We've even met some not so computer-savvy who've thought it's a real biological virus! In addition to viruses, there are trojans, spam, popups and rootkits that can easily take over a system and wreak havoc without you ever knowing. Numerous PCs are infected and slowed down by viruses. There are many that run unstable and users assume that to be their hardware at fault. Unfortunately, many don't have the patience and systems are usually infected, because these rules are broken.

It's not only about viruses today; there are way too many malicious scripts and code in advanced forms that don't really infect PCs, but make the system unusable. Random

reboots, horrible performance, services not running anymore are just some of the visible symptoms. An antivirus isn't sufficient to protect your system. Although many developers still offer standalone antivirus solutions, they're also looking at security suites. They are a combined suite of an antivirus and a firewall system that can also handle spam, filter ADs, and other suspicious content. There are too many solutions available, but we've selected some of the best that are locally available.

A look at the features

While all of the suites have an antivirus and firewall component, there are suites that come with some additional features and is probably where the major differences between the suites will be visible. Norton 360 and McAfee's Internet Security Suite, for

example, came with data backup features. The features let users move data to a different drive, a network share and in the case of Norton 360, even to their online service. The service provides 2 GB of online backup space that can be expanded. This is a great way to ensure no data is lost if your PC gets infected or even if there's a system crash.

Norton 360 has a free downloadable parental control add-on that gives control over every user account on your Windows account and over the kind of content allowed. There is a feature that lets you delay the startup of suspicious applications during bootup. Other than the backup and malware components, special emphasis is on system cleanup utilities as well as security online. G DATA too has a free downloadable add-on for parental control and a file

shredder to delete files and make them unrecoverable. F-Secure InternetSecurity 2009 focuses on parental control, and access to the main control panel is denied unless authorised.

McAfee Internet Security's installer recommends that the installation be downloaded from the internet. The suite even scans the system before the installation to make sure that the system isn't already infected. Another one of the unique features from McAfee is the ability to securely delete files to prevent recovery – something similar to G DATA's file shredder.

Another unique feature of G DATA InternetSecurity is that it constantly monitors the registry. It immediately prompts you whether you want to allow it or block the process that needs to make registry changes. AVG is one the suites

Locked & loaded

Security suites are here to ensure your PC isn't mistaken for a playground for viruses and worms!

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